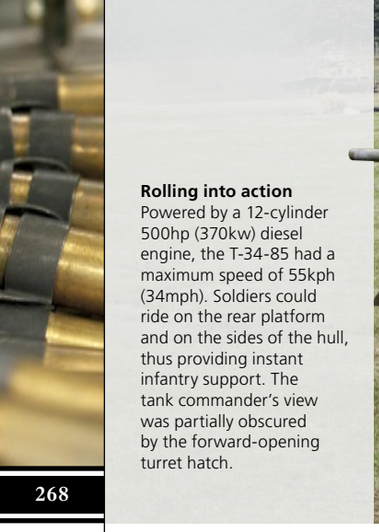




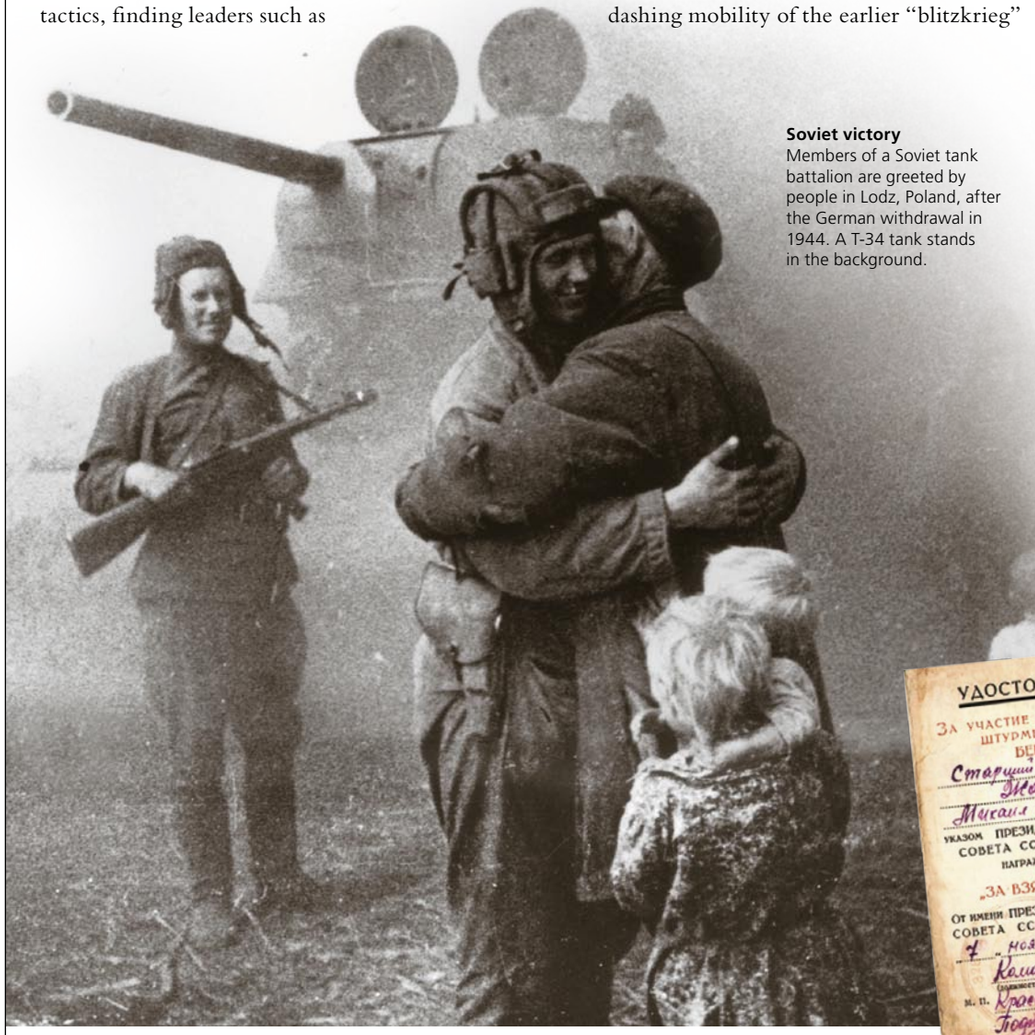
Rolling into action
Powered by a 12-cylinder 500hp (370kw) diesel engine, the T-34-85 had a maximum speed of 55kph (34mph). Soldiers could ride on the rear platform and on the sides of the hull, thus providing instant infantry support. The tank commander's view was partially obscured by the forward-opening turret hatch.



LEARNING CURVE

The Soviet army took a long time to learn how to use its tanks effectively against the German invaders. They typically advanced together in a rigidly drilled formation, groping their way short-sightedly around the battlefield, blundering into German antitank guns and preyed upon by the more flexible panzers, which, in the words of a German tankman, prowled around them "like leopards stalking a herd of bison".

By early 1943, however, the Red Army had sorted out its armoured organization and tactics, finding leaders such as General Pavel Rotmistrov, the commander of 5th Guards Tank Army, who knew how to use armour effectively. The Soviet Union also had ever increasing numbers of tanks pouring out of its factories. Although a core of battle-hardened tankmen had developed, survivors of the fearful losses of the previous two years, many of the crew for the expanding tank arm were inevitably hastily trained draftees, who would have to use courage as a substitute for experience. The armoured warfare they were to undertake from 1943 to 1945 had little in common with the dashing mobility of the earlier "blitzkrieg" era, when German panzers had hammered effortlessly through infantry lines and raced across country in sweeping encircling manoeuvres. Tanks were now to fight in grinding attritional battles that pitted massed armoured formations not only against one another, but also against antitank guns, artillery, infantry antitank weapons, tank-busting aircraft, and mines. This was a context in which tanks were powerless without infantry and artillery support, and in which doggedness, perseverance, and sheer numbers were likely to score over flair and initiative.

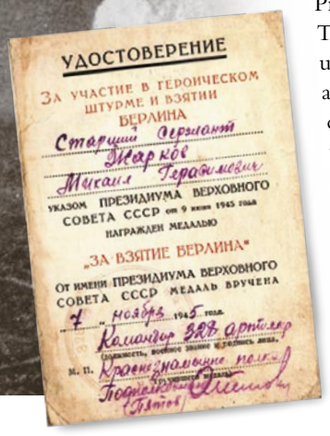


Soviet victory
Members of a Soviet tank battalion are greeted by people in Lodz, Poland, after the German withdrawal in 1944. A T-34 tank stands in the background.

SHOWDOWN AT KURSK

The largest tank battle of World War II took place at Kursk in July 1943. The Germans assembled around two-thirds of their entire Eastern Front armoured forces to the north and south of a bulge, or salient, in the front. They intended to cut the neck of the salient, trapping the Red Army forces inside. Aware of the German plan, the Soviets turned the salient into a fortress defended by minefields, trenches, artillery, and massed armoured formations. The Germans launched their offensive on 5 July. In the north the panzers were fought to a standstill by Soviet antitank guns and tanks in fixed emplacements. But in the south an armoured thrust spearheaded by SS Panzer divisions penetrated to Prokhorovka, 30km (20 miles) behind the Soviet defensive line.

On 7 July Rotmistrov's 5th Guards Tank Army, in reserve more than 350km (217 miles) from the fighting, was ordered to advance to Prokhorovka and counterattack. Travelling by day and night in unbearable heat, the massive armoured column threw up a cloud of grey dust that coated the crews' sweat-soaked skin and choked their parched throats. In a feat of endurance


УДОСТОВЕРЕНИЕ

За участие в героическом штурме и взятии Берлина

Старший сержант Жарков Михаил Герасимович

Указом Президиума Верховного Совета СССР от 9 июня 1945 года награжден медалью

„За взятие Берлина"

От имени Президиума Верховного Совета СССР медаль вручена

7 ноября 1945 года

Командир 328 артполк

м. п.

Tankman's award
This is the front page of the standard commendation that accompanied a medal presented to a Soviet tankman for his part in the taking of Berlin in 1945.